

Figure 3.28 *Old Qandahar cemetery, Burial Mound A, octagonal platform looking south. From Whitehouse 1976: pl. III.*

Mound A (Figure 3.28) contained two sequential burials, each of a small child, both oriented north–south with the faces turned west. The grave also exhibited features seemingly outside strict Islamic burial norms, however: the first body was placed within a small and vaulted, subterraneous mud-brick crypt, marked above ground by a rubble and mortar octagonal enclosure that was itself filled in to create a platform. Atop the first burial was that of another child, still within the octagonal enclosure and platform. The entirety of Mound A had been covered over with earth. The second nearby burial, Mound B, revealed itself to be less elaborate upon excavation, but still following similar protocols: the body of an adult and probably elderly woman facing west was placed in a north–south trench grave, surrounded by a rectangular enclosure, the whole contained within an earthen mound.[92]

Scholarly consensus has generally dated Mounds A and B to the mid-twelfth century, more specifically associating both with the Shansabani presence at Tiginabad/Old Qandahar. The strongest chronological indications for this dating have been the ceramic fragments, whose earliest sequences fell within the twelfth century based on comparable finds from Lashkari Bazar.[93] Moreover, the combination of discernibly Islamic and non-Islamic burial practices in the two graves – and others may yet come to light – could be interpreted as making a stronger case for Shansabani association rather than refuting it: We have noted in Chapter 2 that the Shansabanis' own cultural practices were rooted within the pre- or early Islamic temporal *strata* of west–central Afghanistan, with continuations or modifications over time. It is not impossible, then, that burial practices continuing those of their pre-imperial, and *more* nomadic and/or transhumant forebears were still in place during these early phases of their ascendancy outside historical Ghur.[94]